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STREET WISE
Former PM Imran Khan, seen with other PTI leaders, addresses a rally in Islamabad

my—the government will need to undo some of the populist measures Imran had enacted in his last couple of months. This will mean un-freezing petrol prices for one, a subsidy that is draining government budgets and which, in turn, will lead to further inflation and costs of doing business. These will be very unpopular measures.

In anticipation of this, among Shehbaz's first announcements were increasing the minimum wage, raising pensions by 10 per cent and providing subsidised wheat flour during Ramazan. It's not clear where the money for these populist measures will come from.

This then is the Catch-22 confronting the government: if its attempts to fix the economic mismanagement of Imran fail, it risks shifting public ire from the previous government towards itself. According to one economist, "No government can survive the economic storm awaiting it."

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Meanwhile, Imran Khan threatens further instability. He has already announced a schedule of protests across Pakistan against his ouster and the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) members have announced it will resign en masse from the National Assembly. PTI had also boycotted the election of the prime minister, allowing Shehbaz to be elected 174-0 in the House. While reports indicate that a majority of PTI members are not keen to resign, Imran has categorically stated that he and his party will not sit with "looters and thieves".

It's not the first time that Imran and PTI have had recourse to street protests—in fact, some believe Imran felt more comfortable in that role than as a head of government. And most observers don't believe PTI has the power to sustain its protests, especially in a situation where it has alienated its previous military backers and has become estranged from its rich funders.

Though Imran ironically rails at the current economic crisis, which is partly of his own making, what makes the current scenario dangerous is his recourse to virulent anti-West rhetoric, particularly anti-Americanism, insisting that he was ousted because of an "American conspiracy". This threatens to upset Pakistan's relationships, including trade ties. The allegation of "traitors" in "a conspiracy against Pakistan" could inflame passions among his often young and gullible supporters. The army has already taken note of their "propaganda campaign...to create division between the [army] and society".

Given Pakistan's precarious economic situation, Imran will also seize upon all unpopular measures by Shehbaz's government or a worsening of the situation to create further discontent. As novelist Mohammed Hanif wrote in *The Guardian*, Imran believes that "if he [isn't] in charge of the house, he might as well burn it down". ■